



Stored, Not Kept

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The following is a reflective essay occasioned by Apple's decision to begin removing apps that are not updated, improved, or used. The writer grants the appeal of a world where what we make can simply stay, then asks whether staying is the same as being kept.

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 For most of its life the App Store worked on a quiet promise: build something once, and it could stay. A developer who made a small flashlight app over a weekend in 2009 could publish it and walk away, and the thing would sit there, downloadable, for as long as the store existed. There is a real generosity in that. It lets the work outlast the worker's attention, the way a book, once printed, outlasts the afternoon it was written in. Apple opened the store in 2008 with five hundred apps; it now holds close to two million, and a great many of them are exactly these quiet survivors, made once and left alone.

2 That permanence was a kind of equality. [Concession] It meant a person of no particular standing could put a working thing into the world and have it stay in the world, on the same shelf as the work of large companies, judged by whether it was useful rather than by whether anyone kept tending it. The store took in millions of submissions a year and asked each app to clear the bar once. After that, the app was a tenant with a permanent lease.

3 This month, at its developer conference, Apple said it would change the bar. The rulebook every app must pass now warns that an app already published can be taken down, not for breaking a rule, but for sitting still: 'We may remove these apps from the App Store going forward if they are not updated, improved, or do not attract customers.' Wallpaper apps, plain timers, flashlight apps, the weekend survivors: these are the named examples. It is easy to read this as a landlord finally clearing out the quiet tenants [Metaphor]. But the change exposes something the old promise had let us forget. A thing that is only stored is not the same as a thing that is kept. [Shift / volta]

4 To keep a thing, as opposed to storing it, is to keep working on it; the keeping is the work, not a state the work arrives at; a garden is kept and a shed is stored; a language is kept and a fact is stored [Antithesis]; the difference is never the object but whether anyone is still bent over it.

5 What the old store offered was the shed, and we mistook the shed for permanence, even for a kind of ownership, because the app stayed where we left it. But staying is not living. Most of the two million were never really being kept by anyone; they were being remembered by a database. The store is not a library, where finished things are supposed to rest. It was always closer to a garden, and a garden does not let you walk away.

6 None of this is really about software. The unease the announcement stirs is older than any store, and it has less to do with apps than with how much of what we call having made something is just having left it somewhere. We build, and then we hope the building counts as keeping, because keeping is harder and

does not end. Maybe a place that pulls what no one tends is only admitting what was always true of made things, that they ask to be tended or they quietly stop being ours. Or maybe it is simply colder than the store that let everything stay. The comfortable years were the ones that never made us choose.

Devices, and why they are here:

Concession (paragraph 2): “That permanence was a kind of equality.”

The writer grants the opposing case its strongest form, that the old permanence genuinely served the powerless by letting a small maker's work persist beside a big company's. Conceding this much in good faith is what earns the later turn; the line states the granted value itself, not a claim that the grant is sincere.

Metaphor (paragraph 3): “a landlord finally clearing out the quiet tenants”

Casting the policy as a landlord clearing out quiet tenants gives the abstract change a concrete, slightly sympathetic picture, the easy reading the writer is about to complicate.

Shift / volta (paragraph 3): “A thing that is only stored is not the same as a thing that is kept.”

The turn of the whole essay sits in this claim, not in the 'But' that precedes it. Here the piece pivots from praising permanence to distinguishing it from something better: the difference between an app merely stored and a thing actually kept.

Antithesis (paragraph 4): “a garden is kept and a shed is stored; a language is kept and a fact is stored”

Two balanced pairs set keeping against storing across different objects, making an abstract distinction concrete and testable; a garden and a language are tended, a shed and a fact are merely held.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the fifth paragraph, which best characterizes the writer's position on the App Store's longtime permanence?

- A) It offered the appearance of keeping a made thing while in fact only storing it
- B) It was a plain mistake that the new policy rightly corrects
- C) It mattered only to large companies and not to independent makers
- D) It proved that made things can survive without anyone tending them

2. The writer devotes the first two paragraphs to praising the old 'build once and it stays' model primarily in order to

- A) argue that the company should reverse its new policy
- B) make the later turn against mere storage read as fair rather than as reflexive complaint
- C) give readers step-by-step instructions for keeping an app available
- D) show that the store had always treated developers unfairly

Multiple choice answer key:

1. Answer A. The fifth paragraph says the old store offered 'the shed,' that staying is not living, and that most apps were remembered by a database rather than kept, so the keyed option captures the writer's distinction between the look of keeping and the fact of storage. The plain-mistake option overstates the writer, who concedes the permanence had real value and never calls the policy simply right. The survival-without-tending option inverts the argument, which holds that staying is not the same as living. The large-companies option contradicts the second paragraph, which credits the old model for helping the maker of no particular standing.

2. Answer B. Granting the old model's genuine generosity and equality up front means that when the writer later separates storing from keeping, the criticism cannot be dismissed as knee-jerk nostalgia, which is why the keyed option fits. The reverse-the-policy option imports a demand the essay never makes; it takes no side on whether the removal is correct. The always-unfair option inverts the first two paragraphs, which praise the model's fairness. The instructions option mistakes a reflective essay for a how-to and answers a purpose the text does not serve.

Discussion questions:

1. The writer spends two full paragraphs granting that the old model was genuinely good before turning against it. How does conceding the other side so completely change the way the later argument lands?
2. The essay turns on the difference between a thing that is 'stored' and a thing that is 'kept,' carried by the images of a shed and a garden. How does that distinction change what it means to say someone 'made something'?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. The concession is doing strategic work. By agreeing in full that the old permanence was a real good, even a kind of equality that let small makers' work survive beside big companies', the writer removes the easy objection that the essay is merely nostalgic or anti-technology. Having been visibly fair to the other side, the later claim, that storing is not keeping, arrives as an earned distinction rather than a complaint. A piece that had opened with the criticism would have sounded reflexive; this one sounds like a mind that reached the turn honestly.
2. The distinction reframes making as an ongoing act rather than a finished one. To 'store' is to set a completed object down and walk away; to 'keep' is to stay bent over the thing, tending it, so the work never fully ends. Read that way, publishing an app, or finishing any made thing, is not the same as keeping it alive, and the permanence people prized was really just storage wearing the look of care. The shed and the garden make the idea concrete: one holds what is dead, the other demands a gardener.

Writing prompt (Q3 argument):

The writer claims that 'a thing that is only stored is not the same as a thing that is kept.' Defend, challenge, or qualify the idea that to truly keep something a person has made requires continuing to tend it, rather than simply leaving it in place. Use your own knowledge, observation, or reading.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- That the essay is mainly an argument about Apple or app-store policy. The policy is the occasion, not the subject; the piece uses it to think about the difference between making something and maintaining it, and it takes no position on whether the removal is good.

- That the long concession in the first two paragraphs is the writer's final view. It is ground granted on purpose, in good faith, so that the later turn reads as fair rather than as reflexive complaint.
- That the shift in the argument is signaled by the word 'But.' The connective only flags that a turn is coming; the volta is the claim it introduces, that a thing only stored is not the same as a thing kept. Mark the claim, not the cue word.

AP exam alignment:

This opener is built in the AP English Language source-passage mold. The Long Think register models Rhetorical Situation (Skill Category 1): a writer reasoning aloud to a thoughtful peer, with an exigence that is a durable human theme, the difference between making and maintaining, behind a current news item. The concession-then-rebuttal structure and the withheld distinction give Reasoning and Organization (Skill Category 5) a clear line to trace, targeted by the second multiple-choice item, while the writer's stated position is targeted by the first (Claims and Evidence, Skill Category 3). The two questions test different reading skills. The free-response prompt is a Q3 argument, the fitting choice because the passage advances a contestable claim, that storing and keeping differ, which a student can defend, challenge, or qualify; the same passage would also support a Q2 on the concession structure, and Q3 is chosen here to vary the task across the batch.